TEN CREATURES OF THE SHANHAIJING

Original texts · New translations · D&D Challenge Ratings

CHINESEBESTIARY.COM



Nine-Tailed Fox

九尾狐

The Classic of the Western Mountains describes a fox the size of a dog with nine tails and a cry like a human infant. In the founding mythology of the Xia dynasty, its appearance is an omen of imperial longevity. In later tradition, a fox earns one new tail for every thousand years survived — nine tails marks immortality.

The nine-tailed fox appears in the Shanhaijing as an auspicious omen, not a demon. The dangerous enchantress version is a Tang dynasty development.



Nüwa

女娲

The creator of humanity: she scooped yellow earth from the riverbank and shaped figures that walked away as people. When the pillar of heaven broke and flood and fire threatened to end the world, Nüwa smelted five-colored stones to patch the sky, cut the legs off a great tortoise to prop up the four corners, and killed the Black Dragon of the northern plains. She did not rest.

The Huainanzi records that her five-colored stones patched the sky, but the sky still tilts — which is why all rivers in China flow toward the southeast.



FENGHUANG

凤凰

The phoenix of China is not a resurrection bird — it does not burn and rise from ash. It is a celestial omen that only appears when a sage-king rules. It feeds on dew from the wutong tree, sleeps nowhere else, and its song contains the five tones of the Chinese musical scale. When it flies south in autumn, it takes virtue with it; when it flies north in spring, it brings peace.

The Shanhaijing describes the fenghuang with five-colored markings that form the characters for virtue, righteousness, humanity, trust, and loyalty.



TAOTIE

饕餮

A face with no body: two enormous eyes, a slavering mouth, and clawed hands gripping the sides of its own head. The Taotie is the oldest design motif in Chinese archaeology — it appears on Shang dynasty bronze vessels from 1600 BCE as a mask without a body below the chin. Its name means "greedy glutton." It is one of the Four Perils, the most corrosive forces in the cosmos.

No ancient text explains why the Taotie has no body. One theory: it ate everything, including itself.



QILIN

麒麟

The qilin is the gentlest creature in the Chinese bestiary: it walks without bending a blade of grass, eats no living thing, and breathes fire only in self-defense. It appears as an omen when a sage is born and vanishes when one dies. Confucius, tradition says, was born when a qilin appeared at his mother's house and died the year one was killed in a hunt. He wept.

The qilin has scales, one horn, and the face of a dragon — it is not a horse, and is not related to the giraffe (despite the Yongle Emperor believing otherwise).



CR8

PIXIU

貔貅

The Shanhaijing describes the pixiu as a fierce celestial guardian from the far western mountains, used on military banners to summon courage in soldiers. Han dynasty tomb figures of the pixiu face outward to ward off evil — they are protective, not financial. The modern association with wealth (no exit, only intake) appears in medieval folk religion, not the original text.

The "no anus" detail that drives the modern wealth-magnet belief appears nowhere in the Shanhaijing. The original pixiu is a war beast.



BAI-HU

白虎

The White Tiger of the West rules the autumn sky, the metal phase, and the direction of setting suns and death. As one of the Four Symbols, it governs seven lunar mansions that trace its shape through the western quadrant of the Chinese sky — the same stars that rise in autumn and set as winter comes. Its roar causes wind; its territory is the mountains west of civilization.

The White Tiger constellation in Chinese astronomy corresponds to portions of Orion, Taurus, and Perseus in the modern Western system.



QINGLONG

青龙

The Azure Dragon of the East is simultaneously a divine creature and a star quadrant: seven specific lunar mansions in Virgo, Libra, Scorpius, and Sagittarius trace its shape across the eastern sky. Its rising in spring marks the beginning of the farming year; its heart-star (Antares) rising in summer marks the summer solstice. The Shiji documents both the creature and the star system in the same astronomical treatise.

The Azure Dragon constellation is confirmed real astronomy — documented in the Mawangdui silk manuscripts (168 BCE) and in systematic form in the Shiji (90 BCE).



XIANGLIU

相柳

Nine heads, each feeding from a different mountain. Wherever Xiangliu stepped, swamps formed. The hero Yu killed it — but its blood was so corrosive that nothing could grow where it fell. Yu excavated the kill site three times; three times the earth sank back. He finally built the ceremonial platforms of the gods on top. Xiangliu was the minister of Gonggong, the flood god who broke heaven.

Yu needed multiple attempts to kill Xiangliu. The Ba She was killed by a single archer in a single stroke. This asymmetry is why Xiangliu wins the matchup between the two in our Beast Battles section.



CR ∞

HUNDUN

混沌

Hundun has no face. Where eyes should be there are bumps; where a mouth should be there is smooth skin. The gods, taking pity, tried to give it seven orifices — one per day for seven days. On the seventh day Hundun died. It is one of the Four Perils and the personification of primordial chaos before the world differentiated into form. Its name means both "chaotic" and "wonton soup."

Zhuangzi tells the Hundun story as a lesson in the danger of imposing form on what thrives without it. The gods destroyed the only being that was fine as it was.

Want all 50 creatures?

CHINESEBESTIARY.COM

Original texts · D&D stat blocks · Beast Battles · Stories